



STRATEGIC ACCOUNTS

SAOS User Handbook

Field handbook for strategic account planning

ACCOUNT SELECTION

OPERATING DISCIPLINE

EXECUTIVE TRUST

Contents

The handbook follows the SAOS conversation from purpose and mindset through the practical sections used in account planning.

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Purpose

What SAOS is and why strategic account planning needs its own discipline.

The Strategic Account Operating System (SAOS) is the planning framework for how Great Plains Communications pursues, develops, and expands our most important enterprise accounts.

The tool is not meant to be another CRM form. CRM captures activity. SAOS captures strategic judgment.

For the Strategic Accounts team, this matters because our work is different from standard account coverage. We are not simply selling circuits, voice, security, Wi-Fi, SD-WAN, or managed services. We are helping large, visible, complex organizations make infrastructure decisions that affect operations, resiliency, security, customer experience, and executive trust.

Our target accounts are the kind of organizations that carry weight in the market: multi-location enterprises, large-wallet prospects and customers, headquarters-driven decision environments, public-facing institutions, regional brands, complex operators, and influential logos across Nebraska and the broader Midwest. Think organizations like major construction firms, manufacturers, health systems, government entities, education leaders, financial institutions, nonprofits, specialty retailers, and high-recognition local brands.

SAOS gives us a shared discipline for answering the questions that matter:

- Why would this account change?
- Why would they change now?
- Why would they choose GPC?
- Who actually shapes the decision?
- What is the first wedge?
- What creates trust?
- What expands after the first win?
- What must we learn next?
- What customer commitments do we need, not just what actions do we owe?

The goal is simple: turn account knowledge into account strategy.



Why SAOS Exists

The business case for translating product strength into customer pressure.

Strategic accounts are rarely won by having the best product list. They are won by understanding the account's operating reality better than the incumbent, better than the customer expects, and sometimes better than the customer's own internal teams have organized it.

GPC has a strong platform for this kind of pursuit:

- A high-performing fiber network across the Midwest
- Local teams with Nebraska and Indiana roots
- A 24/7 Network Operations Center in Blair, Nebraska
- Scalable connectivity, managed network, security, cloud, and voice capabilities
- A reputation for responsiveness and custom solutions
- A regional advantage with real proximity to the customers we care about most

But those strengths only matter if we connect them to the customer's actual pressure.

A large account does not buy "network connectivity" in the abstract. They buy:

- Reduced operational fragility
- Fewer outages and escalations
- More resilient multi-site operations
- A better customer, patient, student, citizen, or employee experience
- Lower risk
- More control
- More agility
- A provider they can trust when something goes sideways

SAOS forces us to translate from product language into executive business language.



The Core Mindset

The beliefs behind stronger account judgment.

SAOS is built around five beliefs.

1. Strategic selling starts with account selection.

Not every large account deserves the same level of strategic investment. Tier, wallet, visibility, expansion potential, timing, and market value matter. We need to be intentional about where we spend senior attention.

1. Status quo is the real competitor.

The incumbent matters, but inertia often matters more. The account may know its current network, security posture, provider model, or multi-site architecture is imperfect and still avoid change. SAOS asks us to identify the action-forcing event that makes doing nothing expensive.

1. The org chart is not the buying map.

Titles help, but influence often runs through operators, technical leaders, procurement, finance, executive sponsors, trusted admins, board-level pressure, local facility leaders, and hidden power brokers. Influence Mapping turns contacts into a political map.

1. Expansion is designed before the first deal closes.

The first sale should create proof, trust, and access to the next conversation. SAOS asks us to define the wedge and the expansion path at the same time.

1. Momentum must be logged, not guessed.

Strategic progress is not only stage movement. It is also access gained, risk uncovered, executive language learned, champions activated, skepticism reduced, and customer commitments secured. Relationship Timeline and the 30/60/90 Plan make that visible.



How To Use The Handbook

How to apply the guide in planning, discussion, and inspection.

Use this handbook in three ways:

- Rollout discussion: align the team on the why behind the framework.
- Account planning: use each section as a coaching prompt before customer meetings.
- Deal inspection: separate real strategic progress from busy activity.

The handbook follows the SAOS flow:

1. Account Snapshot
2. The Big Play
3. Competing Priorities
4. The Blindspots
5. Influence Mapping
6. Account Expansion
7. The Battlefield
8. Strategic Entry Points
9. How They Buy
10. 30 / 60 / 90 Plan
11. Relationship Timeline

Some sections are Core and some are Deep Dive. Core is for the practical account plan. Deep Dive is for accounts where the pursuit is complex enough that the psychology, tensions, and unknowns need deeper inspection.



GPC Strategic Account Profile

The account profile where SAOS creates the most leverage.

SAOS is especially useful for accounts with one or more of these characteristics:

- Multi-location operations
- Large network spend or high expansion potential
- Headquarters or major decision presence in Nebraska or the Midwest
- High visibility or reputation value
- Complex IT, facilities, operations, security, or procurement environments
- Mission-critical uptime requirements
- Existing provider frustration or risk
- Upcoming renewal, buildout, merger, cloud initiative, security mandate, or modernization push
- Need for both local responsiveness and enterprise-grade capability

Examples of the account types we care about:

- Construction and engineering firms with distributed job sites and headquarters influence
- Manufacturers with plants, warehouses, and operational technology dependencies
- Healthcare organizations where uptime and security directly affect care delivery
- Government entities where resiliency, procurement, and public trust matter
- Education and nonprofit institutions with high community visibility
- Retail, specialty, hospitality, and food brands where customer experience depends on connectivity
- Financial and professional services firms with security, compliance, and branch connectivity needs

The common thread: the network is not a utility line item. It is an operating system for the business.



Section Guide

The operating components of a complete strategic account plan.

1 Account Snapshot

WHAT IT CAPTURES

The Account Snapshot combines firmographic facts from CRM with strategic judgments from the account team:

- Strategic tier
 - Relationship status
 - AI / cloud maturity
 - Strategic patience
 - Pursuit priority
 - Existing providers
 - Expansion potential
-

WHY IT MATTERS

This section answers: "Is this account worth strategic investment, and what kind of pursuit are we running?"

Strategic teams must resist treating every account equally. A high-notoriety, multi-location account with major expansion potential should be worked differently than a smaller opportunistic pursuit. The snapshot forces prioritization.

For GPC, this is especially important because our strongest opportunities often sit at the intersection of wallet, regional influence, operational complexity, and timing. A large Nebraska-headquartered account can be valuable not only because of revenue, but because it becomes a reference point in the market.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Do not fill this out as an administrative profile. Fill it out as an investment thesis.

Ask:

- Why is this account strategically important to GPC?
- Is the account a logo, a wallet, a wedge, a reference, or all of the above?
- Are we trying to win a first foothold, displace an incumbent, expand an existing relationship, or defend a strategic customer?
- How much patience should we have?
- Is this pursuit worth executive sponsorship from our side?



GOOD EXAMPLE

Tier 1. Existing relationship is limited, but expansion potential is high due to multi-site footprint, local headquarters influence, and growing cloud/security needs. Pursuit priority is high because a successful wedge could create a referenceable enterprise logo in Nebraska.

COMMON MISTAKE

Writing "High potential" without explaining why. The snapshot should explain the strategic reason, not just label the account.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

The Big Play is the central pursuit thesis:

- Why their status quo is broken
 - Why now matters
 - Why GPC is the logical fix
 - Why the account matters to us
 - How executives would describe the need for change
 - Operational pain signals supporting the thesis
-

WHY IT MATTERS

This is the heart of the plan.

Large accounts do not move because we have a better pitch deck. They move when the current state becomes too risky, too slow, too expensive, too fragile, or too misaligned with where the business is going.

The Big Play turns account research into a boardroom-level reason to act.

For GPC, this is where we connect our differentiators to business pain:

- Fiber depth becomes resiliency.
 - Local support becomes operational confidence.
 - Managed services become reduced complexity.
 - SD-WAN becomes multi-site performance and control.
 - Wireless backup becomes continuity.
 - Managed firewall and DDoS become risk reduction.
 - Cloud Connect becomes secure, reliable access to critical platforms.
-

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

The best Big Play is not "we can help with connectivity." It is more like:

Their multi-site operating model is outgrowing a patchwork network approach. The business needs a more resilient, centrally managed connectivity foundation before outages, cloud performance, and security exposure become executive-level problems.

Ask:

- What pain would an executive recognize immediately?
- What is the cost of doing nothing?
- What trigger makes this urgent now?



- What language would the customer use internally?
 - What proof do we have?
 - What proof do we still need?
-

OPERATIONAL PAIN SIGNALS

Pain signals are not random complaints. They are evidence that the status quo is cracking.

Examples:

- Recurring outages across locations
 - Poor application performance
 - Security exposure
 - Cloud cost or cloud access pressure
 - Talent gaps in internal IT
 - Vendor dissatisfaction
 - Compliance risk
 - Legacy network debt
 - Executive mandate for modernization
-

COMMON MISTAKE

Writing a product pitch instead of a change thesis.

Weak:

Sell SD-WAN and DIA to improve the network.

Strong:

The current branch architecture is too fragile for their growth plan. SD-WAN plus resilient access gives IT central control, better app performance, and a path to standardize operations across sites.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

Competing Priorities identifies the tensions inside the account:

- Scale vs. reliability
 - Innovation vs. governance/security
 - Cost vs. agility
 - Cloud vs. control
 - Automation vs. human oversight
 - Speed vs. stability
 - Agility vs. compliance
 - Centralization vs. flexibility
 - Build vs. buy
-

WHY IT MATTERS

Strategic accounts rarely have a single clean priority. They are usually balancing contradictions.

The CFO may want cost control. IT may want stability. Operations may want speed. Security may want governance. Executives may want modernization without disruption.

If we ignore the tension, our message becomes generic. If we name the tension, we sound like we understand the business.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Pick the tension that explains the account's hesitation or urgency.

Ask:

- What tradeoff is slowing the decision?
 - Which internal group is pulling which direction?
 - Which side of the tension should GPC help them resolve?
 - How does our solution reduce the pain of the tradeoff?
-

GPC EXAMPLE

An enterprise wants cloud modernization but fears losing control over performance and security. The GPC story should not just be "Cloud Connect is reliable." The better story is:

We help you move faster into cloud without giving up performance visibility, security, and local accountability.



COMMON MISTAKE

Selecting every tension. The discipline is choosing the few tensions that actually explain the account.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

The Blindspots section is a checklist of unknowns the team must answer.

WHY IT MATTERS

Strategic selling requires intellectual honesty. The strongest account teams know what they do not know.

Blindspots protect us from false confidence. They turn uncertainty into a discovery agenda.

For strategic accounts, unknowns can kill the deal:

- Unknown procurement process
 - Unknown incumbent contract term
 - Unknown executive sponsor
 - Unknown technical risk
 - Unknown budget owner
 - Unknown board-level initiative
 - Unknown multi-site decision model
 - Unknown pain severity
-

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Each blindspot should become a question for the next customer conversation.

Weak:

Need more info on network.

Strong:

Who owns the business impact of branch downtime: IT, operations, finance, or local site leadership?

Ask:

- What must be true for this pursuit to advance?
 - What assumption are we making?
 - What would surprise us later?
 - What question would change our strategy if answered?
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COMMON MISTAKE

Using this as a parking lot. It should be a discovery checklist.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

Influence Mapping organizes contacts by role in the buying system:

- Executive leadership
 - Mid-level champions
 - Technical / operational influencers
 - Bench / unmapped contacts
 - Invisible org chart
 - Political dynamics
 - Access path
 - MEDDPICC role badges: Champion and Economic Buyer
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WHY IT MATTERS

Strategic accounts are political systems.

The buyer is not always the signer. The signer is not always the influencer. The loudest person is not always the champion. The technical evaluator may have veto power. Procurement may shape terms. Operations may define pain. Executives may only care when risk becomes visible.

Influence Mapping forces the team to stop treating "the account" as one person.

CHAMPION VS. ECONOMIC BUYER

Champion:

- Has influence
- Wants our solution or our outcome
- Helps us understand the account
- Coaches us on process and politics
- May or may not own budget

Economic Buyer:

- Can release or approve money
- Owns business impact
- Can prioritize the initiative
- May be insulated from day-to-day pain
- Must understand why change matters

You can have multiple champions. You should identify one economic buyer.



HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Ask:

- Who feels the pain?
- Who owns the budget?
- Who owns risk?
- Who can block us?
- Who can coach us?
- Who benefits personally if this succeeds?
- Who loses power if the provider model changes?
- Who do we need access to that we do not have today?

ACCESS PATH

Access path is the strategy for getting from where we are to where the decision is made.

It should include:

- Current access
- Desired access
- Bridge contact
- Reason the bridge would make the introduction
- Message that earns the meeting

COMMON MISTAKE

Calling someone a champion because they are friendly. A real champion helps us win when we are not in the room.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

Account Expansion defines:

- Initial entry wedge
- Trust creation
- Expansion path
- Opportunity rows across areas like Cloud, Security, AI, Infrastructure, SD-WAN, DR, UCaaS, Wireless, Backup

WHY IT MATTERS

Strategic accounts are rarely maximized in the first transaction.

The first win should be chosen because it creates trust and opens the next door.

For GPC, a wedge might be:

- Dedicated Internet at a critical HQ or location
- Wireless backup for continuity
- Managed firewall for risk reduction
- SD-WAN for multi-site control
- Managed Ethernet for site-to-site transport
- Cloud Connect for performance and security
- Managed Wi-Fi for employee/customer experience

The question is not only "what can we sell?" It is "what first move gives us permission to become more strategic?"

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Ask:

- What is the smallest credible first win?
- What pain does it solve?
- What proof does it create?
- Who will experience the improvement?
- What next conversation does it unlock?
- What larger architecture could this become?



GOOD EXAMPLE

Initial wedge: wireless backup at high-impact locations. Trust creation: prove GPC can reduce outage risk quickly without disrupting existing architecture. Expansion path: use performance and support experience to open SD-WAN and managed firewall conversation across the full footprint.

COMMON MISTAKE

Listing every product as white space. Expansion is a sequence, not a menu.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

The Battlefield combines competitive positioning and incumbent entrenchment:

- How we want to be perceived
 - Incumbent strengths and weaknesses
 - Moat factors
 - Switching costs
 - Relationship dependencies
 - Why the current provider is hard to remove
 - Our displacement narrative
-

WHY IT MATTERS

In strategic accounts, incumbents have gravity. Even unhappy customers may stay because change is risky.

The incumbent may have:

- Existing contracts
- Embedded integrations
- Familiar support paths
- Executive relationships
- Operational dependency
- Procurement preference
- "No one gets fired for staying with the known provider" inertia

The Battlefield forces us to respect that gravity before trying to displace it.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Ask:

- What does the incumbent do well?
 - Where are they vulnerable?
 - What would make the account tolerate switching pain?
 - What proof would reduce perceived risk?
 - Where can GPC be meaningfully different?
 - Is our advantage local support, network design, responsiveness, flexibility, escalation ownership, managed services, or total architecture?
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GPC POSITIONING ANGLES

Useful positioning themes:



- High-performing network, high-performing people
 - Local team, enterprise-grade capability
 - Custom solutions instead of generic bundles
 - Midwest network depth and proximity
 - 24/7 NOC and operational accountability
 - Scalable fiber-driven platform
 - Responsive support from people who know the region
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COMMON MISTAKE

Trash-talking the incumbent. The best displacement strategy respects why the incumbent is still there, then shows why the account has outgrown them.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

Strategic Entry Points are per-contact pursuit playbooks:

- Trust level
 - Responsiveness
 - Political influence
 - Communication style
 - Compound potential
 - Why they matter
 - Operational pain
 - Conversation wedge
 - Next move
 - Mutual connections
 - Human context
-

WHY IT MATTERS

Enterprise selling happens through individuals.

A generic account strategy fails when it meets a real person with their own incentives, style, fears, and priorities. Entry Points translate the account strategy into person-specific action.

This is where the plan becomes usable before a call.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Ask:

- Why does this person matter?
 - What do they care about?
 - What pressure are they under?
 - What kind of message will they respond to?
 - What should we avoid saying?
 - What is the next best move with them?
 - Can they bridge us to someone else?
 - What human context helps us build trust?
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COMMUNICATION STYLE EXAMPLES

Analytical:

- Bring data, diagrams, uptime, risk, cost, and proof.



Driver:

- Be concise. Show impact, timeline, decision path, and executive outcome.

Amiable:

- Build trust. Emphasize support, partnership, and low-risk transition.

Expressive:

- Connect to vision, innovation, customer experience, and visible wins.

COMMON MISTAKE

Repeating the same strategy for every contact. If every entry point says the same thing, we do not have an influence strategy.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

How They Buy captures account psychology:

- Bureaucracy level
 - Risk appetite
 - Technical sophistication
 - Vendor loyalty
 - Decision velocity
 - Organizational gravity
 - Consensus requirement
 - Procurement friction
 - Innovation friction
 - Narrative
 - Bureaucracy bypass strategy when needed
-

WHY IT MATTERS

This section explains the buying motion.

Two accounts can have the same technical need and require completely different pursuit strategies. One may move fast with a strong CIO sponsor. Another may require procurement, legal, security, operations, finance, and site-level consensus.

If we misread how they buy, we create friction instead of momentum.

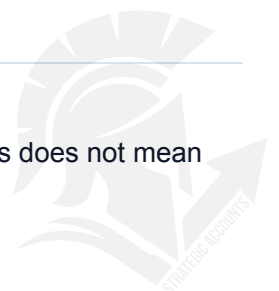
HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Ask:

- Is this account fast or slow?
 - Conservative or bold?
 - Centralized or local?
 - Technical or relationship-led?
 - Loyal to incumbents or open to change?
 - Procurement-heavy or executive-led?
 - Do we need a formal business case?
 - Do we need operational proof first?
-

BUREAUCRACY BYPASS TRAP

When bureaucracy is high and risk appetite is low, the plan must define a bypass strategy. This does not mean skipping process. It means finding a legitimate path through the organization:



- Executive sponsor
 - Pilot
 - Risk workshop
 - Site-level proof
 - Incumbent benchmark
 - Security or resiliency review
 - Business impact assessment
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COMMON MISTAKE

Assuming a strong technical case creates a buying motion. It does not. The buying motion must be designed.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

The 30 / 60 / 90 Plan defines:

- Immediate actions
 - Follow-up meetings
 - Internal tasks
 - Customer commitments
 - Proof points
 - Signals to watch
 - Give/Get expectations
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WHY IT MATTERS

Strategy without next moves is theater.

The 30 / 60 / 90 Plan turns insight into execution. It also prevents the team from mistaking our own activity for account progress.

The strongest version includes not only what GPC will do, but what the customer must do.

THE GIVE/GET PRINCIPLE

Strategic selling requires mutual commitment.

Examples:

- We deliver a network design. They provide site inventory.
- We schedule an executive workshop. They bring IT, finance, and operations.
- We produce a resiliency assessment. They share outage history.
- We bring security expertise. They include the security decision-maker.
- We draft pricing. They confirm decision process and timing.

If the customer gives nothing, we may not have real momentum.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

30 Days:

- Learn, validate, secure access, define pain, confirm process.

60 Days:

- Build proof, engage broader stakeholders, align solution architecture.

90 Days:



- Convert proof into decision path, proposal, expansion plan, or executive commitment.

COMMON MISTAKE

Writing a to-do list with no customer commitment. A real plan includes mutual action.



WHAT IT CAPTURES

The Relationship Timeline gives a chronological view of:

- Strategic signals
 - Manual interaction entries
 - Key insights
 - Momentum scores
 - Optional CRM activity overlay
 - Milestone snapshots
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WHY IT MATTERS

Strategic account progress is not always visible in pipeline stage.

The timeline helps answer:

- Are we gaining access?
 - Is the customer engaging more deeply?
 - Did we uncover new pain?
 - Did a champion emerge?
 - Did momentum improve or stall?
 - Are we learning or just logging activity?
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SIGNALS-ONLY EXPORT POLICY

CRM activities can be promoted into the planning timeline, but exported executive materials only include strategic signals and manual interactions. This keeps boardroom artifacts clean.

The tool distinguishes between:

- Activity: something happened.
 - Signal: something meaningful changed.
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HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

A good signal says what changed, not just what occurred.

Weak:

Had call with IT.

Strong:



IT confirmed branch outages are now visible to operations leadership and asked for failover options before budget planning.

COMMON MISTAKE

Logging every activity as equal. Strategic teams separate motion from momentum.



Field Example

A practical example of the thinking in context.

Multi-Location Enterprise Pursuit

Account context:

Large Nebraska-headquartered organization with multiple operating locations, high public visibility, and a mixed provider environment.

The Big Play:

Their current network model is too fragmented for the scale and visibility of the business. Branch performance, outage risk, and inconsistent provider accountability are becoming operational issues. GPC can create a more resilient, locally accountable platform that supports growth and reduces escalation pain.

Competing Priority:

Scale vs. reliability. The organization wants to expand and modernize, but cannot tolerate instability across locations.

Blindspot:

Who owns the business impact of downtime: IT, operations, finance, or executive leadership?

Influence Map:

IT director is a potential champion. CFO may be economic buyer. Operations leader feels site-level pain. Procurement controls process. Need bridge from IT to executive sponsor.

Expansion Strategy:

Start with high-impact locations where backup, dedicated access, or SD-WAN can prove responsiveness and reliability. Use that proof to expand into managed firewall, cloud connectivity, and broader multi-site architecture.



Battlefield:

Incumbent has familiarity and existing contracts, but support inconsistency and fragmented accountability create vulnerability. GPC should position around local responsiveness, network depth, and managed operational confidence.

30 / 60 / 90:

30: Validate outage history, provider map, and decision process.

60: Deliver resiliency assessment and site-priority architecture.

90: Secure executive review and define phase-one deployment.



Frequently Asked Questions

Common questions before the rollout conversation.

Is SAOS replacing CRM?

No. CRM remains the system for accounts, contacts, deals, activities, and tactical execution. SAOS is the strategy layer for priority accounts.

Does every account need a full SAOS plan?

No. The deeper the account's value, complexity, or visibility, the more complete the plan should be.

Is it okay if sections are incomplete?

Yes, if the gaps are visible and intentional. An honest blindspot is better than a fake answer.

How often should SAOS be updated?

After meaningful account interactions, before major account reviews, and whenever new information changes the strategy.

Who owns the plan?

The account owner owns it, but the best plans are team artifacts. Specialists, sales engineers, managers, and executive sponsors should all contribute where they have insight.

What belongs in exports?

PDF and PowerPoint exports should tell the strategic story. They intentionally exclude promoted tactical CRM activities unless those activities are rewritten as strategic signals or manual insights.



Closing Principle

The simplest standard for strong strategic account plans.

SAOS is not about filling boxes. It is about building strategic judgment.

For GPC, the opportunity is real: we have the network, the local credibility, the managed services portfolio, and the customer-service reputation to win large, visible, complex accounts across the Midwest.

SAOS gives the team a common operating system to pursue those accounts with precision.

The best plans will not be the longest. They will be the clearest.

They will answer:

Why this account, why change, why now, why GPC, who matters, and what happens next?

